used every procedural trick they'd learned in decades on Capitol Hill to block this legislation.

That meant I had to dip into FDR's bag of tricks and take my case to the people.

To his credit, Tip granted my request to speak before a joint session of Congress a week after I left the hospital. I walked in to an unbelievable ovation that went on for several minutes. I explained why I thought tax and budget cuts were essential for ending the economic emergency the nation was facing. At one point, forty or so Democrats stood up and applauded and I felt a shiver go down my spine. I thought to myself: "Boy, that took guts; maybe our economic package has a chance." Later, I joked to someone, "That reception was almost worth getting shot for."

With Tip convinced that I was determined to destroy everything he had worked his entire life for, the Democratic leadership really dug in its heels following that speech. He sent out the word that any Democrat who was even thinking about supporting the tax and budget cuts could expect merciless discipline from the party leadership. And every time he got a chance, he went public and accused me of having horns and trying to destroy the nation. I was never able to convince Tip that I didn't want to deprive the truly needy of the assistance the rest of us owed them; I just wanted to make government programs more efficient and eliminate waste, so that we no longer spent $2 for every $1 of aid we delivered to people.

A few days after my speech to Congress I started to think we might make it. In early May, I wrote in my diary: "More meetings with Congressmen. These Dems are with us on the budget and it's interesting to hear some who've been here ten years or more and say it is their first time to ever be in the Oval Office. We really seem to be putting a coalition together."